

Goal. I want to create a framework to decolonize AI safety research. The framework will evaluate epistemic & physical violences witnessed by people involved in its development and operations. I will contrast how BigTech AI serves disproportionately impacts people inside the imperial core (generally, WEIRD populations) and the periphery (generally, the majority world). This framework aims to unearth the extractive logics embedded in every layer of BigTech AI lifecycle, from data collection to model training, from extraction of minerals that form the physical AI infrastructure to privacy policies of the AI interfaces used by consumers. The framework will provide opportunities that shape AI safety that incorporates sustainability and sovereignty.

Scholars have noted that computing research and interventions reflect an imperial impulse [1–3]. However, without engaging with theories of change that center decoloniality, sovereignty, and liberation [4, 5], safety research may result in neoliberal siloed interventions that fail to address the privacy violations of peoples that power the Big Tech enterprise. For example, trust & safety teams in Big Tech companies often tout their products as private, ethical, carbon-neutral, whereas, the same companies actively exploit miners who extract rare earth minerals in Congo and assemble their products in India. On a similar vein, what does privacy mean for exploited factory workers in India who watch abusive content or wear cameras to train AI robots that will soon replace them? Similarly, ChatGPT promises privacy settings that ensure users’ data is not used for model training, yet also, legally allows abusers to generate fake nude images of their victims without consent. A narrow definition of privacy & safety only brings surface level interventions that rarely addresses the underlying structural violence and prevents communities from achieving long-term healing and liberation.

Methods. My computing and critical theory expertise allows me to view technologies not just as a black box, but as a combination of abstract social and technical components. I study impacts of violence through user-facing technologies (e.g. mobile accounts, airtags) and from physical infrastructures (e.g. AI data centers, AMBER alerts). I will surface the underlying neoliberalism and coloniality in digital safety research across security & privacy, HCI, and social computing venues. To do this, I will build on my workshop proposal that calls for extending the definition of violence that transcends disciplinary boundaries [Rejected Workshop DIS 2026]. I will generate keywords of concepts that capture the power differentials among people involved in the development of an AI model using the ‘Calculating Empires’ framework [7, 8]. Then, I will use automated scraping methods [In-review CSCW 2027] and snowball sampling to collect a wide collection of AI-related research articles and news reports that formally or informally define privacy in global contexts. I will categorize these definitions into mode of harms, the actors involved (including people and the land), their impacts on actors, and, the mitigation strategies to negotiate and address privacy concerns. Next, I will interview stakeholders embedded in some aspects of the AI lifecycle e.g. communities organizing against AI data center, survivors of interpersonal violence using AI for support, immigrants who face social media surveillance, or, researchers that work on AI privacy research. The interview will utilize the Meta-Relationality protocol [10] to surface a diverse set of orientations around affect (feelings about different kinds of AI?), mitigation strategy (what theory of change informs their response to AI?), time (how does the time of shape their stance?), and, agency (what kind of leverage is possible and required?). Findings from the interviews will result in a composite set of that show the agreements and contradictions across value-systems, social positions, and, proximity to AI knowledge creation and usage. These contestations are necessary to inform the privacy interventions so that they centers agency and liberation from AI-mediated violence: whether that may be refusal on ethical grounds, regulatory action or guardrails, resistance movement, decentralized alternatives, sabotage from within academia or corporations, or, eco-social symbiotic technologies.

My Publications

[Rejected Workshop DIS 2026] Jasmine C Foriest, Alicia DeVrio, Li Qiwei, Nimra Ahmed, **Naman Gupta**, Jeneile Raihan, Franchesca Spektor, and Justine Zhang. “Violence as a Boundary Object: Language, Power, and Design Justice”. en. In: 2026.

[In-review CSCW 2027] **Naman Gupta**, Sophie Stephenson, Chung Chi Yeung, Wei Ting Wu, Jeneile Luebke, Kate Walsh, and Rahul Chatterjee. ““Lighting The Way For Those Not Here”: How Technology Researchers Can Help Fight the Missing and Murdered Indigenous Relatives (MMIR) Crisis”. en. In: *Under review at CSCW*. 2025.

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